SCAM DECODED · LARGE PRINT

Scam Decoded for Seniors

The large-print guide to spotting phone, text, email and computer scams

- 5 golden rules that stop most scams
- The 5 calls to hang up on
- Fill-in “who I call first” page
- Fridge checklist and cut-out wallet cards

General education, not legal or financial advice. Phone numbers checked November 2026. All example calls, texts and names are made up. © Scam Decoded. For personal and family use.

START HERE

The 5 golden rules

Scammers are professionals. Smart, careful people get fooled every day. These five rules beat almost every trick.

1. **Don't trust the caller ID.**
   Scammers can make any name or number show up.

2. **Hang up, then call back.**
   Use a number you look up yourself: on your card, your bill or the official website.

3. **Never pay in a hurry.**
   Real banks and agencies give you time. Scammers never do.

4. **Never pay with gift cards, wire transfers, crypto or cash by courier.**
   Only scammers ask for these.

5. **Never share a code.**
   If someone asks for the code that was just texted to you, it's a scam.

PHONE CALLS

5 calls to hang up on

The grandchild in trouble

“Grandma, it's me. I'm in jail. Please don't tell Mom.”

Hang up and call your grandchild, or their parent, on the number you already have. Voices can be faked with AI.

The government

“This is Social Security. Your number has been suspended.”

Social Security, the IRS and Medicare don't call to threaten you or demand payment. Hang up.

Your bank's “fraud department”

“We've stopped a suspicious charge. Read me the code we just sent.”

Your bank will never ask for that code. Hang up and call the number on the back of your card.

Computer support

“Your computer has a virus. Let us connect to fix it.”

Microsoft and Apple don't call you. Never let a caller on to your computer.

You've won a prize

“You've won $2.5 million! Just pay the taxes and fees first.”

Real prizes are never paid for. If you have to pay, you didn't win.

TEXTS AND EMAILS

Don't tap the link

Scam texts look like they come from the post office, your bank or the toll road. If you're not sure, go to the company yourself.

“Your package can't be delivered. Pay $1.99 to reschedule.”

Check the delivery company's own app or website.

“You owe an unpaid toll. Pay now to avoid a fine.”

Look up your toll account yourself. Don't tap the link.

“Your bank account is locked. Tap here.”

Call the number on the back of your card.

“Hi, is this Margaret? Sorry, wrong number!”

Don't reply. A friendly chat that follows often turns into an investment scam.

Free: forward scam texts to **7726**, then delete them.

ONLINE FRIENDS AND ROMANCE

When a new friend needs money

Romance scammers spend weeks being kind before they ask for anything. Watch for someone:

- Someone you've only met online who soon says they love you
- Who can never meet or video chat
- Who then needs money for a ticket, a medical bill, customs or a “sure” investment

The rule: never send money, gift cards or crypto to someone you have only met online. No matter how real they feel.

Investment “opportunities”

If a new online friend shows you how much they've made on an app or with crypto, it's almost always a scam. The app's numbers are fake, and the money can't be taken out.

Talk to someone

Tell a family member or friend about your new friend. A scammer will try to keep you from doing that. That alone is a warning sign.

COMPUTERS AND PHONES

The scary pop-up

“WARNING! Your computer is infected. Call Microsoft Support now: 1-8XX-XXX-XXXX.”

Don't call. Close the browser. If it won't close, turn the computer off and on again.

- Real warnings never give you a phone number to call.
- Never let anyone you don't know control your computer (“remote access”).
- Never log in to your bank while a stranger is on the phone or on your screen.
- Already let someone in? Turn the computer off, call your bank, and ask a trusted helper to check it.

Passwords

Use a different password for your email than for anything else, and turn on “two-step” sign-in. Ask a family member to help you set it up. It takes about 10 minutes.

WHAT TO SAY

Your hang-up lines

You never have to be polite to a stranger who calls you. Pick one line and say it out loud a few times now.

1. “I don't do business on the phone. I'll call you back on the number I have.”
2. “I'm going to check with my family first.”
3. “Send it to me in writing.”
4. “No, thank you.” (Then hang up. You don't owe them a goodbye.)

Pick a family safe word. Agree on a word with your family that a scammer could never guess. If someone calls “in trouble”, ask for the word.

Our word: _____

NUMBERS YOU CAN TRUST

Official numbers

These are real numbers to call. Scammers sometimes copy official names, so dial these yourself.

Who	How to reach them
Report a scam to the FTC	**ReportFraud.ftc.gov or 1-877-382-4357**
National Elder Fraud Hotline (US Dept. of Justice)	**1-833-372-8311 (1-833-FRAUD-11)**
AARP Fraud Watch Network helpline (free for anyone)	**1-877-908-3360**
Social Security	**1-800-772-1213**
Medicare	**1-800-633-4227 (1-800-MEDICARE)**
Stop most sales calls: Do Not Call Registry	**1-888-382-1222 or DoNotCall.gov**
Forward scam texts for free	**7726 (spells SPAM)**

Checked November 2026. If a number doesn't work, look it up on the official .gov website.

FILL THIS IN

My important numbers

Write these from your cards and bills, not from a call or text.

Who	Number
My bank (back of my card)	
My credit card company	
My doctor / pharmacy	
My phone company	
I call first if I'm unsure	

IF IT HAPPENS

The first hour

Acting fast gives you the best chance of getting money back.

1. **Stop.** Don't send any more money, even if they say it will get the first payment back.
2. **Call your bank** on the number on your card. Ask them to stop or reverse the payment.
3. **Gift cards?** Call the gift card company on the number on the back of the card, and keep the card and receipt.
4. **Tell someone you trust.** Scammers count on you keeping it secret. It is not your fault: these are professional criminals.
5. **Report it** at ReportFraud.ftc.gov or call the Elder Fraud Hotline: 1-833-372-8311.
6. **Watch for the second scam.** Anyone who calls offering to “recover” your money for a fee is another scammer.

KEEP BY THE PHONE

Before I pay, click or share anything

1. Caller ID can lie. A real name on the screen means nothing.
2. Never pay with gift cards, wire transfers, crypto or cash.
3. Never share a code that was texted to you.
4. Never let a caller on to your computer.
5. Hurry + secret + unusual payment = SCAM.
6. Hang up. Call back on a number you look up yourself.
7. Not sure? Call someone on my list below first.

I call first	Phone number

Report a scam: **1-877-382-4357** · Elder Fraud Hotline: **1-833-372-8311**

WALLET CARDS · FRONTS

Cut along the dashed lines. Print double-sided (flip on long edge), or glue front to back.

STOP. Is this a scam?

1. Hurry? Secret? Strange payment? **Stop.**
2. Never gift cards, wire, crypto or cash.
3. Never share a texted code.
4. Hang up. Call back on a number I look up.

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WALLET CARDS · BACKS

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Before I pay, I call:

Name

_____

Phone

_____

Report a scam: **1-877-382-4357**
Elder Fraud Hotline: **1-833-372-8311**

Before I pay, I call:

Name

_____

Phone

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